fear of antagonizing the trade union leader. Ratan later said that nobody was willing to support him except Neelkanth Kalyani, an agriculturist who founded the Kalyani Group.

The opposition did not come only from the expected quarters. Nair had a strong but invisible supporter in Russi Mody. Mody was in constant touch with Nair and ‘stoked’ the unrest in Pune, said J.J. Irani, who was the president of the research and development wing of TISCO at that time and later its MD.

The unrest did not, however, demotivate Ratan. Instead, it brought out a lesser-known facet of the shy gentleman’s personality. As he has often said, Ratan is no ‘quitter’. Soon after he became chairman of TELCO, he went on a charm offensive to win the workers’ trust. Within a fortnight, he wrote a letter to all the company employees. He also partook in wage negotiations, something that no MD or chairman had done before.

He began his letter, dated 23 December 1988, by saying how it was a ‘great privilege’ to be appointed chairman of TELCO. He outlined the ‘exciting’ future the company would have by ‘rapidly’ improving its range of vehicles. He referred to the difficulties the company was facing and ended the letter stating that he was looking forward to ‘facing these challenges together’ with the employees. He also did not forget to add that with him, their grievances would not go unheard.

However, Ratan was clear on who he would choose to address. He refused to acknowledge the congratulatory messages sent by the TKS, as well as Nair, on his appointment as chairman. By addressing the employees and not sending a reply to the trade union leaders, he communicated that he would not accord them more importance than those who worked for the company.

Labour problems, however, continued to plague the company. The situation came to a head on 31 January 1989, when Ratan visited the Pune plant for the first time as the company chairman. The workers greeted him on the shop floor with a tool-down strike. The atmosphere was tense and volatile.

To avoid any breach of peace during Ratan’s visit, Nair had been taken into preventive custody by the police on the day of the chairman’s arrival. This enraged the workforce. Company buses containing a large number of workers who were to come for the second shift at the plant at Pimpri were